Red Herring

Written by

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INT. DORM ROOM - MORNING

JIMMY (18) lays face down on the floor of his dorm, still wearing the clothes from the night before. The room is littered with cans, trash, and a red substance resembling BLOOD.

Jimmy's PHONE rings, startling him awake. He picks himself up off the floor and looks around. He notices the blood stained on his hands, clothes, and floor.

JIMMY
(Whispering to himself)
What the fuck?

He examines his body for whatever injury caused the blood. He finds nothing.

The panic starting to really set in, Jimmy scours his room for the source. Looking in the bed, closet, and on the floor for an explanation.

Someone knocks at the door.

BARRY
Hey! It's Barry!

Jimmy mouths the word "FUCK", leaning forward as if in physical pain.

BARRY (CONT'D)
How are you doing? You seemed really out of it when you came home last night.

JIMMY
Did I?

BARRY
Yeah and you had this...this look on your face...Anyways! Me and the guys are going to iHOP tonight if you wanted to join? I know you're busy but its been awhile and-

JIMMY
Yeah, maybe man...It's not really a good time but, um, I'll let you know.

BARRY
Oh, alright man. No problem. I-I'll see you.

Jimmy waits until Barry's footsteps fade before going back to panicking. He paces the floor and calls his best friend, FREDDY (18), who doesn't answer.

JIMMY
Freddy, dude, I don't know what's going on but I-I need you to come over right now. Something happened man, I don't know! I'm really freaking out, JESUS, please hurry.

Jimmy hangs up the phone and begins frantically wiping his hands clean before starting on the bloody floor.

JIMMY (CONT'D)
(to himself)
Its okay, you didn't kill anyone, you didn't kill anyone...

He stands looks around and checks his phone - no response. He grabs his BAG and leaves.

CUT TO:

INT. CLASSROOM HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS (AMS)

Jimmy paces in front of a closed classroom door. As students start filing out, Jimmy makes his way to FREDDY (19), who is wearing a leather jacket and sunglasses.

FREDDY
Hey man, you good? I got your message. Are you still fucked up?

JIMMY
Ha... no I-um, well, you just, um, have to promise not to freak out.

FREDDY
(laughing)
Okay?

JIMMY
Seriously. I can't have you freaking out on me I'm really scared man and-

FREDDY
J! Jesus, I'm fine. Cool as a cat.

Freddy grins again, devilishly.

CUT TO:

INT. DORM ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Freddy stands in the middle of the room, slowly looking around as he takes in the scene. Jimmy leans against his bed frame, watching Freddy.

FREDDY
W-what happened man?

JIMMY
I don't know.

A beat.

FREDDY
WHAT DO YOU MEAN YOU DON'T KNOW?!?

Freddy, abandoning any cool he might have had, puts his hands on his head and stares at Jimmy.

JIMMY
I DON'T KNOW! YOU SAID YOU'D BE COOL!

FREDDY
I AM COOL! I am cool...

Freddy, composing himself, puts a hand on Jimmy's shoulder. He is unable to keep his cool long.

FREDDY (CONT'D)
FUCK WHY DID YOU CALL ME? DOESN'T THAT MAKE ME A-AN ACCOMPLICE OR SOMETHING?

JIMMY
AN ACCOMPLICE?! I DIDN'T DO ANYTHING!

FREDDY
YOU DIDN'T?!

JIMMY
I DON'T KNOW!

This sends them both into a tense silence. Freddy chews on his nails, pacing.

FREDDY
J... this morning Amelia was talking about her missing cat. It disappeared last night Jim, LAST NIGHT.

JIMMY
I DIDN'T KILL AMELIA'S CAT! Wh-what would have possibly led to me doing something like that...

Freddy suddenly makes his way to the door.

JIMMY (CONT'D)
Where are you going?

FREDDY
Jimmy, dude... I got to get the FUCK out of here man. You gotta tell Amelia or the police... I don't know but not me man, not me!

Freddy leaves.

JIMMY
FREDDY! FUCK! Please don't go.

Jimmy, alone, turns back toward his messy dorm room. He calls Freddy who doesn't pick up. He calls again: no response. He leaves.

CUT TO:

INT. DORM HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Jimmy paces in front of AMELIA'S dorm. He bites his nails and goes up to knock. He chickens out. He paces back and forth again, stops, looks at the door, and pulls out his phone.

JIMMY
H-hey mom

His mom's voice responds inaudibly.

JIMMY (CONT'D)
I needed to tell you that, well, something happened. I don't know I just I think I messed up. I need your help, I don't know what to do-... no, no Mom don't put Dad on... I am still on track...no Dad, I didn't drop out...
(pause)
I-it's okay I'm just stressed...yeah midterms... I just wanted to hear your voice...I love you too... bye.

Jimmy pockets his phone and looks at the door. As he is about to knock a loud cacophony of noise interrupts him.

Jimmy is surrounded by a large group of guys being led by Freddy.

FRAT GUY
GIVE IT UP EVERYONE TO OUR NEW PRANK SUPERSTAR...FREDDYYYYYY!

The group erupts in cheers. Jimmy looks at Frank, wide-eyed.

JIMMY
W-what?

FREDDY
Oh dude, every year Sigma Alpha Pi choses one rushing sophomore to prank a freshman.

Jimmy stares for a moment.

JIMMY
Are you serious?

Freddy's grin turns into a frown. He scoffs.

FREDDY
It's tradition..part of initiation dude...

Jimmy looks around at the people, nodding his head slightly.

FREDDY (CONT'D)
Don't worry if anything it'll only help you during rush next year. We cool?

JIMMY
(scoffs)
Yeah man, we're cool...

He gives Freddy a small smile before turning and walking through the crowd.

Down the hall, Jimmy stops and looks at his hands, still slightly stained with fake blood. He laughs to himself and pulls out his phone.

JIMMY (CONT'D)
Hey Bar, you guys still going to iHOP?

END.